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amount of information to make businesses more efficient and responsive to clients and customers. Data are collected and mined in a number of sectors, including retail, telecom and finance. However, retail sector has the highest level of interaction with a huge volume of customers from different walks of life and hence retailers are very interested in closely understanding their customers.

them and specific products on which shoppers spent appreciable time. The software can integrate this information with other factors such as staffing levels, weather, product variety and placement to conclude what makes sales happen.

In the future, computer programs, with information from video cameras, will determine customers' gender and interpret their facial expressions and

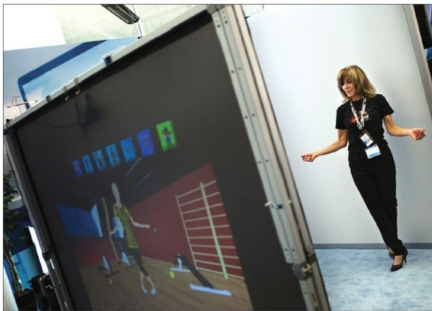


Fig. 3: A lady in front of the Intel Magic Mirror (Source: <http://newsroom.intel.com>)

You login to your favourite e-commerce site to buy a handset. You shortlist one and put it in your virtual shopping cart. However, as you read customer reviews further, you end up changing your mind. You then discover that every online store that you visit features an ad for that very handset. This happens as online retailers can give you a virtual identification number and track your journey from site to site, displaying purchase-targeted ads for products of your interest—this is also known as 'ghost marketing.'

A firm has developed a computer program that enables a store's security cameras to give the management different types of information about how consumers interacted inside the shopping area. It tells precisely the number of customers present inside the store at a time, areas of the store explored by

other gestures to help retailers understand why someone did or did not buy a given product.

Endpoint

Technology as well as buying behaviour is evolving at breakneck speed and retailers who wait for others to drive touchpoint adoption will find themselves to be losers. Since in the post-recession era, there are no rapid-growth new markets, the growth itself will come at the expense of competition. Hence it is important that retail companies keep pace with technology developments and use them to the fullest to become more efficient and effective. ●

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